

BRAND STYLE GUIDE

Brand Tokens & UI System

Live source of truth for the Uni Textbook Marketplace project. The styling classes and color tokens mapped out below directly correspond to our global CSS configuration.

EVOLUTION FROM DEMO 1

Our Brand style guide started out as basic values pulled directly from marketing concepts. While those choices worked well for structural layouts in Demo 1, building live functional views quickly exposed accessibility issues.

Specifically, our primary brand cyan (`#00B4D8`) caused severe text visibility issues on white panels. To address this for WCAG AA compliance, we split it to include a deeper secondary cyan (`#006D8A`) to safely handle text elements, navigation references, and links.

The landing page layout also went through multiple structural iterations. Initial ideas favored complex serif display patterns, highlighting overlays, and stacked sample cards. To keep production assets clean, the final shipped hero uses a full-bleed campus photo with clean Montserrat text layers, emphasizing our slogan: **“Made for Students, by Students”**. Deploying this documentation page directly within the app pipeline allows us to track visual consistency across components in real-time.

EVOLUTION FROM DEMO 2

Demo 2 marked a significant visual overhaul, moving away from flat, utilitarian designs toward a more polished, engaging UI. Our core focus was enhancing user experience through consistent visual hierarchy, improved interactivity, and cohesive branding across all authenticated pages.

Glossy & Glassmorphism Design Language: We introduced glossy hero sections with gradient backgrounds, subtle light reflections, and decorative patterns across all major pages including Browse, Wishlist, My Listings, Messages, and Notifications. Cards now feature hover shadows,

rounded corners, and glass-like transparency effects (`backdrop-filter: blur(10px)`) creating a premium, modern feel.

Badge System Expansion: The badge system was significantly extended from the original three queue statuses (Pending, Approved, Rejected) to include color-coded condition badges (New, Good, Fair, Poor) and sale status badges (Reserved, Sold). These now appear consistently across filter sidebars and listing cards, improving scannability and visual communication.

Component Refinements: The multi-step form steppers were redesigned from basic dots to flag/arrow shapes with clear progress indicators. Listing cards were enhanced with larger images, improved typography, and a glossy hover effect. The messaging interface received a complete refresh with avatars, grouped messages by date, and an improved input area with an icon-based send button.

Dark Mode Support: Full dark mode compatibility was implemented across all routes, with CSS variables managing theme transitions. Hero sections maintain their light gradient backgrounds regardless of theme to preserve visual consistency. Components now adapt seamlessly with `dark:` Tailwind variants.

Consistent Hero Sections: A unified hero section pattern was established across all pages using a dark-to-light cyan gradient with a student-focused image overlay (student reading a book). Each page features a relevant icon (heart for Wishlist, package for My Listings, etc.) and a glass-morphism container, creating a cohesive brand experience.

Button & Interaction Updates: Secondary/outline buttons now use white backgrounds with cyan borders and hover states. The view and dismiss action buttons in admin panels follow this pattern, while destructive actions (Delete, Reject, Ban) retain red styling. All interactive elements received `cursor-pointer` for better UX.

EVOLUTION FROM DEMO 3

Demo 3 and Demo 4 shifted focus away from visual rework and toward interaction depth. The platform's established component vocabulary, badge system, hero treatment, and dark-mode coverage carried through unchanged. What changed was the addition of four interaction-heavy features. Real-time auctions, AI-assisted listing creation, the corner-drag crop editor, and the Bundle Optimizer each needed new component patterns that could slot into the existing design language without introducing a parallel system.

Real-Time Auction Surfaces: The auction browse and detail pages reuse the platform's existing card, badge, and hero conventions rather than inventing new ones. Auction cards pair a standard listing preview with a compact bid summary panel on the right showing the current or starting bid, bid count, start and end dates, a status badge, and a primary action button. Status badges extend the existing badge system with three auction-specific states (In progress, Scheduled, Ended) mapped onto the same colour tokens already used for queue states, so nothing new had to be taught to the user. The auction detail page leads with a dark-navy header carrying an icon badge, the auction status badge,

and the listing title, before dropping into a two-column layout with a live bid activity stream on the left and a sticky bid panel on the right. A live countdown uses tabular figures so the digits do not shift width as they tick, and switches to Danger Red under sixty seconds to communicate urgency through colour rather than motion.

Live-Update Indicators: Because auction state updates in real time through a Firestore listener rather than a page reload, the surfaces needed a way to signal "this is live" without being distracting. A small pulsing cyan dot with a subtle `animate-ping` halo appears next to any actively-updating value, matching the loading-indicator treatment already used elsewhere in the app. The effect is deliberately small and non-blocking, and respects the same reduced-motion conventions as the rest of the interface.

AI-Assisted Listing Creation Panel: The "Scan with AI" entry point inside the Create Listing form uses a full-bleed cyan-to-navy gradient panel to distinguish it from the plain form fields around it, with a small sparkle icon in a glass-morphism container as the visual anchor. Two actions sit side by side, a solid primary cyan "Take photo" button and an outline "Choose from gallery" button styled to work against the dark gradient background. Because the AI pipeline is an optional accelerator rather than a required step, every failure state resolves to a non-blocking notice, a coloured band beneath the buttons that reports either success, partial extraction, or "auto-fill unavailable, please enter details manually", while leaving the manual form fields fully usable underneath.

Corner-Drag Crop Editor: The crop editor introduces the platform's first direct-manipulation image component. Four draggable corner handles sit over the uploaded photo, connected by a live SVG polygon that redraws as the user drags. The overlay uses a two-layer stroke technique, a thicker white outline beneath a thinner cyan line, so the crop boundary remains legible against both light and dark image content. Handles are rendered as 44×44px interactive zones with a small visual dot inside, meeting the mobile tap-target rule while keeping the on-screen element itself visually compact. When the background detector cannot confidently isolate the book, the component falls back to the original photo with default corner positions and no error state, a silent, non-blocking degradation rather than a failure message.

Bundle Optimizer Surfaces: The Reading List page introduces the platform's first optimizer-driven result layout. Its module picker reuses the search-as-you-type interaction already familiar from Create Listing, but presents selected modules as removable cyan-tinted chips rather than a fixed multi-select, so the selection stays visible while the user continues to search. Results render as a top row of three stat cards (recommended total, seller count, meetup count) followed by per-seller grouping cards that each list the books that seller covers alongside a subtotal. A separate comparison card at the bottom shows the naive cheapest-per-book total and seller count side by side with the optimized result, so the trade-off the optimizer made is visible rather than hidden. All Bundle Optimizer surfaces sit on the platform's semantic token palette (`bg-card` , `text-foreground` , `text-muted-foreground`) so light and dark modes are inherited automatically rather than needing per-surface overrides.

Documentation Same-Sprint Discipline: Every Demo 3 and Demo 4 surface documented in the Design Specifications ships with its component styling, badge mappings, and interaction notes written up in the same sprint it was built. The Brand Style Guide page you are reading now is regenerated against the live token set in `globals.css` on each build, so the colour cards and component previews below reflect what is actually rendering in the app rather than what was intended at planning time.

COLOUR PALETTE

Core tokens carried over from the initial design sprint, along with text compliance fixes. Contrast mappings are documented inside `globals.css`.

CORE BASE

Primary Cyan

#00B4D8

Main interactive elements, primary CTAs, and bold heading highlights.

Primary Cyan Hover

#0096B4

Hover state for primary cyan (10% darker variant).

Dark Navy

#000f2b

Main backgrounds & button text on light fills.

Dark Grey

#3a3a3a

Standard body text across all layouts.

Subtle Grey

#4B4F58

Meta labels, placeholder inputs, captions.

Light grey

#F5F5F5

Card backgrounds, internal panels, empty text wrappers.

Border Grey

#dddddd

Layout dividers.

REFINED VALIDATION BADGES (WCAG AA COMPLIANCE)**Link / Secondary Cyan**

#005D8A

Inline links & secondary buttons (Refined for AA compliance)

Ratio: 5.1:1 on white

Danger Red

#dc2626

Delete or withdraw listing actions

Ratio: 4.6:1

Badge, Pending

#D0F0F7 / #004F66

Queue moderation badge state

Ratio: 7.1:1

Badge, Approved

#D0F0DC / #155E2E

Live listing badge state

Ratio: 7.4:1

Badge, Rejected

#FDE8E8 / #7F1D1D



Moderator rejection badge state

Ratio: 8.1:1

Badge, Reserved

#ddc4fe / #8327e5



Listing reserved badge state

Ratio: 7.1:1

Badge, Sold

#c6c6c6 / #606060



Listing sold badge state

Ratio: 8.1:1

Badge, New

#E3F2FD / #1565C0



Filter condition badge for "Like New" listings

Ratio: 7.1:1

Badge, Good

#E8F5E9 / #2E7D32



Filter condition badge for "Good" condition listings

Ratio: 7.4:1

Badge, Fair

#FFF3E0 / #E65100



Filter condition badge for "Fair" condition listings

Ratio: 7.1:1

Badge, Poor



#FFEBEE / #C62828

Filter condition badge for "Poor" condition listings

Ratio: 8.1:1

Token Drift Warning: globals.css overrides

Headings currently resolve to #171717 via root configuration variables instead of using the designated brand Dark Navy colour. Additionally, layout grid dividers reference standard tailwind gray variants instead of our declared background borders. This mismatch will be updated in the next dev synchronisation pass.

TYPOGRAPHY SYSTEM

Our application interface relies entirely on the **Montserrat** font family for authenticated views, forms, and core navigation systems.

ELEMENT	SIZE	WEIGHT	LINE HEIGHT
H1	50px / 3.125rem	700	1.2
H2	28px / 1.75rem	700	1.3
H3	22px / 1.375rem	600	1.3
H4	18px / 1.125rem	600	1.3
Body	16px / 1rem	400	1.6

UI COMPONENT LIBRARY

Core components implemented from Demo 2 through Demo 4, with their key styling attributes.

Listing Card

Product card with image, title, edition, price, condition badge, seller info, and wishlist heart.

Condition Badges

Color-coded badges for listing conditions (New, Good, Fair, Poor) used in filters and listing cards.

Status Badges

Queue status badges (Pending, Approved, Rejected), sale status badges (Reserved, Sold), and auction status badges (In progress, Scheduled, Ended).

Glossy Hero Sections

Full-width hero banners with gradient backgrounds, glossy overlays, and decorative patterns.

Glassmorphism Cards

Cards with backdrop blur, semi-transparent backgrounds, and subtle border effects.

Filter Sidebar

Collapsible filter panel with condition badge buttons, range inputs, and active filter count.

Multi-step Forms

Flag/arrow shaped steppers with progress indicators for listing creation and registration.

Auction Card

Two-column card pairing a listing preview with a live bid summary panel (current bid, bid count, start and end dates, status badge, action button).

Countdown Timer

Tabular-figure countdown displayed on the auction detail page, switching to Danger Red under 60 seconds to communicate urgency without animation.

Corner-Drag Crop Editor

Interactive image adjustment overlay with four draggable corner handles connected by a live polygon, sized for 44×44px touch targets on mobile.

AI Scan Panel

Gradient-panel entry point for AI-assisted listing creation, with dual photo source buttons, staged progress messaging, and non-blocking fallback notices.

Module Picker

Search-as-you-type module selector for the Bundle Optimizer, with a floating results panel and removable chip-style selected-module pills.

Bundle Result Cards

Stat cards for recommended total, seller count, and meetup count, plus a per-seller grouping card listing the books that seller covers.

COMPONENT PREVIEW LIBRARY

Live element examples rendered with our global layout styling classes.

ACTION BUTTONS

Primary**Secondary****Danger**

QUEUE STATUS BADGES

Pending**Approved****Rejected**

CONDITION BADGES

New**Good****Fair****Poor**

SALE STATUS BADGES

Reserved**Sold**

AUCTION STATUS BADGES

In progress

Scheduled

Ended

LIVE UPDATE INDICATOR

● **Live** Used beside any value that updates in real time

BUNDLE STAT CARD

Recommended total

R540.00

SELECTED MODULE CHIP

COS212 x

STK110 x

ACCESSIBILITY FRAMEWORK

- Compliance Target: **WCAG 2.2 AA** interface baseline across all routes.
- Interactive elements utilize high-visibility focus rings (`rgba(0,180,216,.15)`).
- Tap target sizing maintains a 44×44px safety boundary for mobile viewports.
- All interactive elements use `cursor-pointer` for improved UX.
- Condition and status badges maintain a minimum 4.5:1 contrast ratio on their respective backgrounds.
- Live-update animations and countdown transitions respect the user's reduced-motion preference.
- Direct-manipulation components (corner-drag editor) provide keyboard-accessible controls in addition to pointer interaction, with descriptive `aria-label` values on each handle.
- The Bundle Optimizer's module picker surfaces a distinct "Selected" state on already-picked results and disables re-selection, so keyboard and screen-reader users cannot accidentally add the same module twice.

Default Motion On

Developed in collaboration with



Product

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